



Telehealth: Community mental health (Mental Health) Guideline

Preamble

Consumer Participation

The Rockingham Peel Group (RKPG) recognises and fully supports the need for the patient and/or their primary carer to¹:

- Know and exercise their healthcare rights.
- Be engaged in their healthcare.
- Have access to information about treatment options.
- Participate in treatment decisions.
- Have access to information about agreed treatment plans.

Scope of Practice

It is the responsibility of each health care provider to ensure all patient care and therapeutic interventions they provide are within their individual scope of practice. Refer to the [RKPG Guidelines to Writing for Clinical Policy](#) for further information about Scope of Practice.

Introduction

- The following guidelines have been developed to inform and guide clinicians and staff across Peel and Rockingham Kwinana (PaRK) Community mental health service, in providing and delivering safe, high quality and cost-effective care, utilising technology-based equipment.
- Our aim is to support the WA Health Clinical Services Framework to provide consumers and carers with equitable access and choice in delivering community mental health services at PaRK Community Mental health service via this technology.
- In April 2014 WA Health introduced a new governance structure for information and Communications Technology (ICT). The primary aim of the governance structure is to ensure that the right ICT systems are in place to enable WA Health to provide safe, high quality, accountable and effective health care for Western Australians in a financially sustainable environment.
- These guidelines apply to all RKPG Mental Health staff and employees of other organisations supplying care under the governance of RKPG.

Definitions

- **Audio-visual communication (AV):** is a form of communication which has both a sound and a visual component such as videoconferencing to provide real time, synchronous video and audio transmission between locations.
- **Desktop videoconference:** applications that allow WA Health staff to conduct an audio or video conference via the desktop to communicate with other health department staff. A microphone and webcam are required.
- **Telehealth:** A term that describes the use of ICT applications (telephone or video conferencing) to provide healthcare virtually to clients and carers over a distance. The term telemedicine or telepsychiatry may also be used in this context and an

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appointment occurs in a similar way as it would in person. It also allows for one or more multidisciplinary healthcare providers to participate in the same consultation.

- **Videoconference:** A web-based, consumer-centred video consulting application that can be operated via the desktop. Consumers can access this through a site called health direct. They are not required to install software or download applications. They require a webcam and microphone or a smart phone.
- **Teleconference:** Audio only interaction between two (2) or more participants using telecommunications technology (telephone exchange).

Principles

- A telehealth consultation is a type of clinical appointment that can be selected based on an assessment of clinical risks and needs to offer therapeutic value for a consumer of a mental health service who may prefer a consultation in the comfort of their own dwelling.
- Where possible or assessed as clinically appropriate, a telehealth appointment can be offered by clinicians to consumers and carers as an alternative to a home visit or community appointment.
- Telehealth appointments are not intended to replace home visits or community appointments in metropolitan regions. Home visiting and community appointments can still be conducted and may include the additional clinical advantage of linking up with other medical and/or health care providers to continue treatment in situ.
- When delivering virtual mental health care by telehealth clinicians must observe the standard legal requirements, duty of care and code of ethics for each of the disciplines (**refer to the legal and ethical standards section below and your professional code of ethics**).
- Consumers or carers who are willing to participate in a telehealth consultation must be:
 - * Informed about the technology, process and rationale for the use of telehealth.
 - * Informed that there may be a cost to them using the technology which is not covered by the service e.g. cost of data to use the software.
 - * Agreeable to develop a plan for follow up if the telehealth sessions fails due to technological issues i.e. complete the session by telephone.
 - * Assured that they are able to decline telehealth appointments as they are optional and may be given alternatives.
 - * Informed of any impacts to their care if they decline a telehealth session e.g. possible time delay in appointment.
 - * Invited to be a part of planning and delivery of telehealth as well as involved in evaluation of the use of this technology.
- Telehealth consultations are to be appropriately recorded in the client's medical record and psychiatric services online information system (PSOLIS) systems. See records management below.
- RKPG MH will use the authorised applications for telehealth in line with up to date direction from the Health Department IT department.
- The Mental Health Tribunal and Office of the Chief Psychiatrist provide updates to mental health services on the use of telehealth. Mental health services are to act in line with their directives relating to matters pertaining to the Mental Health Act 2014.

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Risks

- Telehealth consultations may be subject to limitations, such as an unstable network connection, which may impact on the quality of the clinical consultation.
- Unsatisfactory delivery of virtual healthcare services may also compromise consumer mental health outcomes becoming a disincentive to consumers and carers (including regional, remote and culturally and linguistically diverse (CaLD) families) to access telehealth services.
- Inappropriate use of network communication tools compromising consumer and carer privacy and confidentiality.

Legal and ethical standards

- Telehealth delivery of mental health care is governed by the same standard legal and ethical requirements as for face-to face community appointments and home visits.
- Staff providing telehealth consultations have the same responsibilities and indemnity cover.
- Staff must make themselves known to the consumer and confirm the identity of the consumer at every interaction as per:
 - * [RKPG Identification of Patients \(Photographic\) Procedure](#)
 - * [RKPG Patient Identification Policy](#)
- Telehealth consultations must take place in a location that satisfies minimum confidentiality standards in accordance with [DoH Patient Confidentiality Factsheet](#)
- Refer to [South Metropolitan Health Service \(SMHS\) In Home Video Consultation Guidelines](#) and [Videoconference Etiquette](#) policies for further information.
- Use of Telehealth and other technology must be in line with the [Department of Health \(DoH\) Acceptable-Use-of-Information-and-Communications-Technology-Policy](#)

Recording

- The capturing of images or recording of telehealth sessions is not recommended and all participants in Telehealth should be advised of this prior to any consultations.

Records management

- All telehealth consultations are to be considered service events and must be appropriately documented in the consumer's medical record and on the services electronic recording systems. This should include evidence of the consent to participate or not.
- In PSOLIS the event medium should be 'videoconference'.
- The location of the consumer must be documented i.e. home address.
- Documentation if any other person is present during the telehealth consult.
- Document a plan for follow up if the telehealth technology fails.
- Documentation must align with [RKPG Documentation Clinical Practice Standard \(CPS\)](#).
- Refer to [Department of Health \(DoH\) State-wide Standardised Clinical Documentation \(SSCD\) for Mental Health Services](#) for completion of documents pertaining to mental health.

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Training

Clinicians wishing to use the telehealth technology platforms should have a working knowledge of the technology. Training can be provided or arranged through their line manager.

Access and use

Consumer and carer interactions

- Clinicians may conduct telehealth consultations from their computer, laptop, mobile device or videoconference-enabled meeting or conference room using applications approved by the Department of Health (DoH).
- All venues must satisfy minimum patient confidentiality standards [DoH Patient Confidentiality Factsheet](#).
- Only health department approved applications can be used for telehealth consultations.
- The health service is not responsible for any cost associated with the telehealth consultation.
- The health service does not take any responsibility for poor connection or failure of telehealth services. The service will offer an appropriate alternative if telehealth services are disrupted or not available.

Non-patient interactions including case conferences, clinician to clinician contact

- Participants in a videoconference that does not involve a patient must:
 - * Secure their own videoconference enabled venue.
 - * Use approved DoH platforms for telehealth communication.
- The health service is not responsible for any cost associated with the telehealth consultation.
- The health service does not take any responsibility for poor connection or failure of telehealth services. The service will offer an appropriate alternative if telehealth services are disrupted or not available.

External users (Ruah; consumers and carers etc.)

- External users including carers, consumers and health professionals from other organisations are:
 - * Responsible for sourcing their own telehealth or videoconferencing equipment including but not limited to laptop, webcam and microphone, smart phone or any other videoconferencing device
 - * Responsible for any cost associated with the telehealth consultation.
- The health service is not responsible for any cost associated with the telehealth consultation.
- The health service does not take any responsibility for poor connection or failure of telehealth services. The service will offer an appropriate alternative if telehealth services are disrupted or not available.

Compliance monitoring

Compliance with this procedure will be monitored by any clinical incidents via Datix.

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References

1. Australian Commission on Safety and Quality in Health Care (ACSQH). The National Safety and Quality Health Service Standards Safety and Quality Improvement Guide: Standard 1 Governance for Safety and Quality in Health Service Organisations. 2nd ed. (Version 2) 2021. Available from <https://www.safetyandquality.gov.au/our-work/assessment-to-the-nsqhs-standards/>

Links

[DoH Acceptable Use of Information and Communications Technology Policy](#)

[DOH Chief Psychiatrist's Standards for Clinical Care](#)

[DoH Information and Communications Technology Governance Policy](#)

[DoH Information Security Policy](#)

[Department of Health \(DoH\) State-wide Standardised Clinical Documentation \(SSCD\) for Mental Health Services](#)

[DoH Patient Confidentiality Factsheet](#)

[RKPG Clinical Handover-Nursing Midwifery \(Acute\) Guideline](#)

[RKPG Community Home Visiting Policy.](#)

[RKPG Communication and Documentation Mental Health HiTH](#)

[RKPG Documentation Clinical Practice Standard \(CPS\).](#)

[RKPG Evening and After Hours MH HITH Guideline](#)

[RKPG Identification of Patients \(Photographic\) Procedure](#)

[RKPG Medical Clinical handover \(Acute\) Policy](#)

[RKPG Patient Identification Policy](#)

[RKPG Physical Health Care: Community Mental Health Consumers \(Mental Health\) Policy and Procedure](#)

[RKPG Referral, Admission and Discharge: Mental Health Hospital in the Home \(Mental Health\) Policy and Procedure](#)

[SMHS Community/home visiting Policy](#)

[South Metropolitan Health Service \(SMHS\) In Home Video Consultation Guidelines](#)

[Videoconference Etiquette](#)

National Standards



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